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Two faces of activation attitudes. Explaining citizens' diverging views on demanding versus enabling activation policies

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Abstract

This study examines public attitudes towards two types of ALMPs: enabling activation, which prioritises training, skill formation, and human capital improvement; and demanding activation, which involves leading people towards employment through sanctions and benefit cuts. While previous research has predominantly focused on demanding activation, this study is the first to compare public support for the two distinct faces of activation. Analysing data from the 2020 Belgian National Elections Study, we examine the role of self-interest, political ideology, social justice preferences, and stereotypical images towards the unemployed in explaining both types of activation attitudes. We find that attitudes towards enabling and demanding activation policies are clearly distinct in their measurement and driving forces. While the enabling type appeals especially to the principle of equality and positive attitudes towards the unemployed, support for demanding ALMPs is based on the principle of equity and stereotypical views about the jobless.

KEYWORDS

active labour market policies, demanding vs. enabling activation, legitimacy of policies, public opinion, self-interest, social justice beliefs, stereotypes about the unemployed

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1 | INTRODUCTION

The increasing implementation of active labour market policies (ALMPs) represents arguably one of the most significant transformations of European welfare states since the 1990s (Cox, 1998; Graziano, 2012; Häusermann, 2012), although the speed and intensity of this 'activation turn' vary considerably across nations (Bonoli, 2010). Labour market activation entails a transition from traditional benefit schemes for the unemployed to programs aimed at re-integrating them into the labour market, often referred to as a shift from welfare to workfare (Rueda, 2015). To increase labour market participation, a wide range of policy instruments is applied, typically categorised into two types of ALMPs. On the one hand, enabling activation follows a social investment logic and focuses on job search programs, human capital improvement, fiscal incentives, and in-work benefits. Demanding activation, on the other hand, encourages employment by means of stricter availability criteria, activity requirements, and sanctions (e.g., benefit cuts) for non-compliance (Bonoli, 2010; Dingeldey, 2007; Eichhorst et al., 2008). The activation turn represents a veritable shift in policy paradigm (Van Hoogtem, Rossetti, et al., 2023), individualising social risks and placing personal responsibility on the unemployed for their misfortune (Dwyer, 2000; Giddens, 1999; Webster, 2019). As activation has become a prominent topic in societal debates and has wide-ranging political implications (Arndt, 2013; Fossati & Häusermann, 2014; Schwander & Manow, 2017), understanding its public legitimacy and feasibility for implementation becomes crucial. After all, the public legitimacy of policies plays an important role in the policy cycle via mechanisms of policy feedback (Kumlin & Stadelmann-Steffen, 2014) and policy responsiveness (Brooks & Manza, 2006).

A growing body of literature investigates the drivers of public support for activation policies. These studies highlight the role of self-interest variables, such as personal experience with unemployment, perceived unemployment risks, and low income (Buss, 2018; Fossati, 2018; Kootstra & Roosma, 2018; Rossetti et al., 2021, 2022). Additionally, activation support is related to a range of ideological dispositions and normative beliefs, including egalitarianism, authoritarianism, deservingness considerations and social justice beliefs (Carriero & Filandri, 2018; Gielens et al., 2019; Houtman, 1997; Laenen & Meuleman, 2019; Rossetti et al., 2021; Van Hoogtem, Rossetti, et al., 2023).

Existing studies on citizens' support for activation policies have mainly focused on exploring determinants of *demanding* activation. Empirical evidence on the support base of *enabling activation* is scarcer, although a growing number of studies (Busemeyer, 2017; Fossati & Häusermann, 2014; Garritzmman et al., 2018) explore citizens' attitudes towards social investment policies, which show conceptual overlap with enabling activation. A systematic comparison of the determinants of support for both approaches is warranted but largely missing (for a notable exception, see Garritzmman et al., 2018). Although both enabling and demanding activation share a common focus on increasing labour market participation and encouraging individual responsibility, their policy approaches and underlying legitimising norms differ significantly (Bonoli, 2010; Dingeldey, 2007). Enabling activation is rooted in a more libertarian left-wing tradition that emphasises social investment and equality of opportunity, while demanding activation is embedded in a more neoliberal approach that is strongly linked to conditionality and obligations (Deeming, 2015; Dwyer, 2000; Garritzmman et al., 2018; Häusermann et al., 2022). As a result of these differences, two types of activation may attract support from constituents with distinct social backgrounds and varying ideological views on society, unemployment and redistribution. Understanding which groups support the two approaches and for which reasons – self-interest, ideology, or a mixture of both – is crucial to gaining insights into their legitimacy and feasibility.

The central research question of our study is: 'To what extent are attitudes towards enabling and demanding activation policies distinct or similar in their measurement, popularity, and explanations?' To answer this question, we collected primary survey data in Belgium through the 2020 Belgian National Elections Study. We validate a newly developed instrument that measures the two aspects of activation support as distinct dimensions. Subsequently, we examine whether support for demanding and enabling activation are differently associated with (1) social structural variables reflecting self-interest and (2) a range of ideological dispositions, such as social justice beliefs, egalitarianism, attitudes towards the unemployed and left-right placement. Considering that social structural characteristics

are not independent from ideological views, a mediation model is put forward, which allows us to uncover to what extent social-structural characteristics reflect self-interested concerns or rather different ideological dispositions. Our findings indicate clear distinctions in the measurement and driving forces of attitudes towards enabling and demanding activation policies. Before elaborating more upon these results, the theoretical framework is further expanded.

2 | THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

2.1 | Two faces of activation: Enabling versus demanding policies

Since the 1990s, welfare states and labour markets across Europe have been subjected to activation reforms aimed to facilitate jobless people to (re-)enter the labour market (Eichhorst et al., 2008). This ‘activation turn’ (Bonoli, 2010) builds on a shift in ideological outlook that increasingly prioritises employment (Bonoli & Natali, 2012; Taylor-Gooby, 2008). This recommodification is accompanied by a stronger emphasis on the individual capabilities and responsibilities of welfare recipients (Greer, 2016; Taylor-Gooby, 2008). *Activation*, as a term, encompasses a range of measures cross-cutting various welfare and labour market policies, including unemployment benefits, social assistance or childcare.¹ Two approaches to activation are usually distinguished.

First, the *enabling* approach focuses on enhancing human capital and providing welfare recipients with resources to develop their skills, such as training schemes or mobility grants. This approach finds its roots in Sweden, where activation policies were introduced in the 1950s to empower workers by upskilling and re-inserting them into the labour market and society, thereby promoting full employment (Bonoli, 2010; Eichhorst et al., 2008; Fossati, 2018; Weishaupt, 2011). The enabling activation approach has mainly been supported by social democratic governments, which strongly emphasized human capital and skills development (Taylor-Gooby, 2004). Enabling activation can be seen as an important pillar of social investment policies that tackle the new social risks of post-industrial societies by creating, mobilising or preserving skills of individuals (Garritzmann et al., 2018; Häusermann, 2012; Häusermann et al., 2022). Enabling activation is conceptually also related to the human capability (Morel & Palme, 2017) and life-first (Dean, 2007) approaches that consider human capital or work not as a goal in itself, but as a means to allow individuals to lead a flourishing life.

Second, the *demanding* approach focuses on work conditionality, strict requirements on welfare recipients as well as sanctions for non-compliance (Dingeldey, 2007; Eichhorst et al., 2008). This workfare approach is based on the “work-first” idea that originated in the United States (Handler, 2004). While the enabling approach uses behavioural incentives rather than punitive measures (Dingeldey, 2007), demanding activation uses sanctions as repressive instruments (Eichhorst et al., 2008; Raffass, 2017), urging jobless people to re-enter the labour market quickly, often at the expense of job quality (Fervers, 2021). Since the 1990s, the demanding approach has gained popularity among European policymakers (Knotz, 2018), mainly promoted by centre-right parties (Taylor-Gooby, 2004). In contrast to the seeming stability of spending on enabling measures, spending on unemployment benefits has gone down, potentially due to stricter eligibility criteria and benefits reductions (reflecting the demanding approach). Although data limitations complicate direct comparisons, and despite cross-national variations, this trend suggest that demanding ALMPs are gaining traction (Bonoli & Natali, 2012).

In Belgium – the research site of this study – internal political and linguistic fragmentations have complicated the path towards activation (Hemerijck & van Kersbergen, 2019). Despite these difficulties, the past two decades have seen an intensification of activation measures. In 2004, the “Activation and job search support” scheme was introduced, initially for young unemployed, then gradually extended to the older persons (Van Lancker et al., 2015). The scheme aimed to keep unemployed people motivated to actively look for jobs, through periodic evaluation of the jobseeker's search behaviour and sanctions if the search requirements were not met (Van Lancker et al., 2015). With this scheme, and a further tightening of controls and sanctions between 2012 and 2016, the Belgian

unemployment insurance has moved to the direction of increasing demanding activation. Although Belgian unemployment benefits remain, in principle, unlimited in duration, policy-makers are increasingly inclined to implement digressiveness (Vermeerbergen & van Echtelt, 2019). Spending on unemployment benefits has significantly decreased from 1.20% of the GDP in 2004 to 0.74% in 2019 (OECD, 2019), reflecting a shift towards less generous unemployment benefit schemes.

2.2 | Support for enabling versus demanding activation: Divergent explanations

Because of the distinct nature of demanding and enabling ALMPs, their support base is likely to differ significantly. To scrutinise whether enabling and demanding activation support are driven by divergent factors, we elaborate on two explanatory frameworks, namely self-interest considerations and ideological dispositions (Buss, 2018; Fossati, 2018; Jaeger, 2006; Jaime-Castillo, 2013; Rossetti et al., 2021, 2022; van Oorschot, 2006). Both frameworks are relevant for both types of activation, but which exact factors have an influence and in which direction could vary across both forms of activation.

Self-interest theory postulates that individuals make calculations about the personal costs and benefits associated with the implementation of social policies (Kangas, 1997). Individuals are assumed to maximise their interests and benefits relative to costs, leading them to support policies that yield individual economic advantages and oppose policies that harm their interests. In the empirical literature, self-interest theory is often tested by analysing the impact of social-structural variables, such as occupational status, unemployment risk, income, or education. The underlying assumption is that these variables are linked to the (perceived) likelihood of individuals becoming the target of a particular policy.

The extent to which ALMPs work for or against the interest of the unemployed critically depends on the type of activation. In relation to demanding activation, a rational choice perspective predicts that unemployed individuals (or those at risk of job loss) will oppose increased conditionality and sanctioning, which are characteristics of this type of activation (Achterberg et al., 2014; Carriero & Filandri, 2018; Kootstra & Roosma, 2018). The incentive structure of enabling ALMPs is very different, as it offers unemployed individuals guidance in their job search, opportunities to upgrade their skills, and sometimes even fiscal incentives. If these measures are recognised as beneficial opportunities, unemployed individuals are expected to be supportive of enabling activation. Notwithstanding the social investment goals of enabling activation, unemployed persons might perceive strongly encouraged career guidance programs and job trainings as instruments of control, leading them to oppose rather than embrace enabling activation. Due to these counter-acting mechanisms, the social-structural gradient in support for enabling activation may be less pronounced compared to the case of demanding activation (Garritzmman et al., 2018).

For the variable unemployment status, this link with support for activation is straightforward, as it is a direct indicator of being subject to the rights and obligations contained in ALMPs (Buss, 2018; Fossati, 2018; 2021). However, for other variables, such as educational attainment, occupational class or gender (Ingold & Etherington, 2013), the effects do not necessarily reflect objective interests but could be the result of socialisation into a particular ideological worldview (Rossetti et al., 2021). Therefore, to observe the self-interest effect of social-structural variables, we must also account for ideological differences as an alternative indirect mechanism.

This is based on a second line of argument that stresses that policy support is embedded in a broader ideological worldview or system of moral orientations (Jaeger, 2008; Staerklé et al., 2012). According to this framework, individuals support government initiatives that align with their normative beliefs. Political left-right position is often used to operationalise the ideology hypothesis. The logic of demanding activation, with its conditional notions of solidarity and emphasis on work obligations for the unemployed, resonates most among right-leaning individuals (Fossati, 2018; Laenen & Meuleman, 2019; van Oorschot, 2006). As a result, for demanding activation, we expect that especially right-wing individuals will be in favour of this type of activation policy.

For enabling activation, ideological lines become somewhat blurred, as it transcends conventional conflicts between labour and capital (Bonoli, 2010; Häusermann, 2012; Weishaupt, 2011). Social investment integrates elements from both traditional left and right, striking a balance between a strong state intervention and individual responsibility. This ambiguity is also reflected in the – sometimes conflicted – stance trade unions take towards enabling activation (Häusermann et al., 2022). Nevertheless, enabling activation relies heavily on public investments into the human capital of the unemployed to stimulate equal opportunities. Building on previous studies on support for social investment policies (Garritzmans et al., 2018), we assume that support for enabling activation will be stronger among left-leaning individuals.

However, since the left–right position is too generic to fully capture the intricacies of the ideological underpinnings of activation support (Van Hoogtem, Rossetti, et al., 2023), we additionally focus on normative beliefs about distributive justice that underpin the two activation approaches. Commonly, three principles of distributive justice are distinguished, organising the balance between rights and obligations in different ways: equality, equity and need (Deutsch, 1975). While equality aims to provide everyone with the same resources irrespective of additional requirements, equity links benefits to previous contributions such as taxes and work history.² Need grants welfare state resources only to those genuinely in need of support, reflecting a residual conception of the welfare state. These principles are core elements of the paradigms upon which social policies are built, as they inform the institutional design of welfare policies in general and activation in particular (Daguerre, 2007; Daigneault, 2014; Dingeldey, 2007; Romano, 2018).

According to the moral economy and policy feedback literatures, citizens may ground their support on the normative principles underlying social policies (Kumlin & Stadelmann-Steffen, 2014; Mau, 2003; Sachweh, 2012; Taylor-Gooby et al., 2018). Since enabling and demanding activation policies have a distinct architecture in terms of underlying justice principles, public support for each approach may be driven by very different justice preferences. Although both activation types share a common goal of increasing labour market participation by emphasising individual responsibility (Dingeldey, 2007; Pintelon et al., 2013), we first of all expect that support for demanding ALMPs will particularly resonate with the principle of equity, as its implementation strongly relies on a quid-pro-quo welfare model that is conditional on the fulfilment of job-searching activities (Ervik et al., 2015). The relationship between the principle of need and support for demanding ALMPs is less clear-cut and depends on how need is conceptualised (Kittel, 2020). When need is interpreted as the residual and selective redistribution of the liberal welfare regime, it connects to support for demanding ALMPs. This interpretation of need distinguishes between deserving and underserving claimants (Clasen & van Oorschot, 2002; Dwyer, 2000; Romano, 2018), which leads us to expect a positive link between the principle of need and demanding activation. However, it can also be interpreted as a concern for the well-being of the worst-off in society and the provision of a sufficient living standard for all citizens. From that perspective, need-based reasoning could be related negatively to the demanding side of activation. Previous research has documented both a positive (Van Hoogtem, Rossetti, et al., 2023) and a negative effect (Van Hoogtem, Abts, & Meuleman, 2023) of the need principle on demanding activation, depending on how the need principle was operationalised.

While enabling policies also incorporate elements of equity to some extent (Pintelon et al., 2013), they are significantly less conditional and do not impose strict sanctions if certain criteria are not met. Instead, the social investment strategy of enabling ALMPs aligns strongly with the principle of equality, albeit a particular kind: equality of opportunity. Enabling ALMPs aim to foster social inclusion and enhance capabilities to achieve equal opportunities for all, which is closely linked to an egalitarian interpretation (Morel et al., 2011; Pintelon et al., 2013). If the need principle is understood as a preoccupation with the living standard of those in need, support for this principle could relate positively to support for enabling policies. This is because enabling policies are designed to increase the human capital of those in need of support, while demanding policies can threaten the livelihood and job quality of those in need and tend to stigmatise the needy (Fervers, 2021).

As a third and final aspect of ideological worldviews, attitudes towards unemployed individuals may be a relevant driver of support for activation. Demanding activation is connected to a relatively bleak and suspicious view

towards the unemployed, assuming that they must be forced into paid work. In this sense, this policy agenda subscribes to the stereotypical view that unemployed are essentially unwilling to take control of their own situation and are work-shy (Buffel & Van de Velde, 2019; Furåker & Blomsterberg, 2003; Rossetti et al., 2022; van Oorschot et al., 2017). In contrast, enabling activation seems to hold a more empathic stance towards jobless individuals, as it invests in human capital and skill development. This type of activation acknowledges that factors such as lacking qualifications or a fractured connection to the demands of the job market can contribute to unemployment, rather than attributing it to work ethic deficiencies or voluntary reliance on the welfare state.

2.3 | Hypotheses

Testing these theoretical arguments requires an integrated approach that takes the potential interplay between social-structural variables (such as unemployment status, income, occupation, and education) and ideological dispositions (left-right position, justice preferences and attitudes towards the unemployed) into account. While self-interest theory suggests that the effects of social-structural variables are driven by cost-benefit considerations, irrespective of ideological preferences, it is known that different social categories adhere to distinct ideological preferences (for a similar argumentation, see Rossetti et al., 2021). To disentangle this interplay, we use a mediation approach, wherein social-structural variables have both a direct (self-interest) effect on activation support and an indirect effect via ideological factors. Figure 1 visualises all relationships of interest.

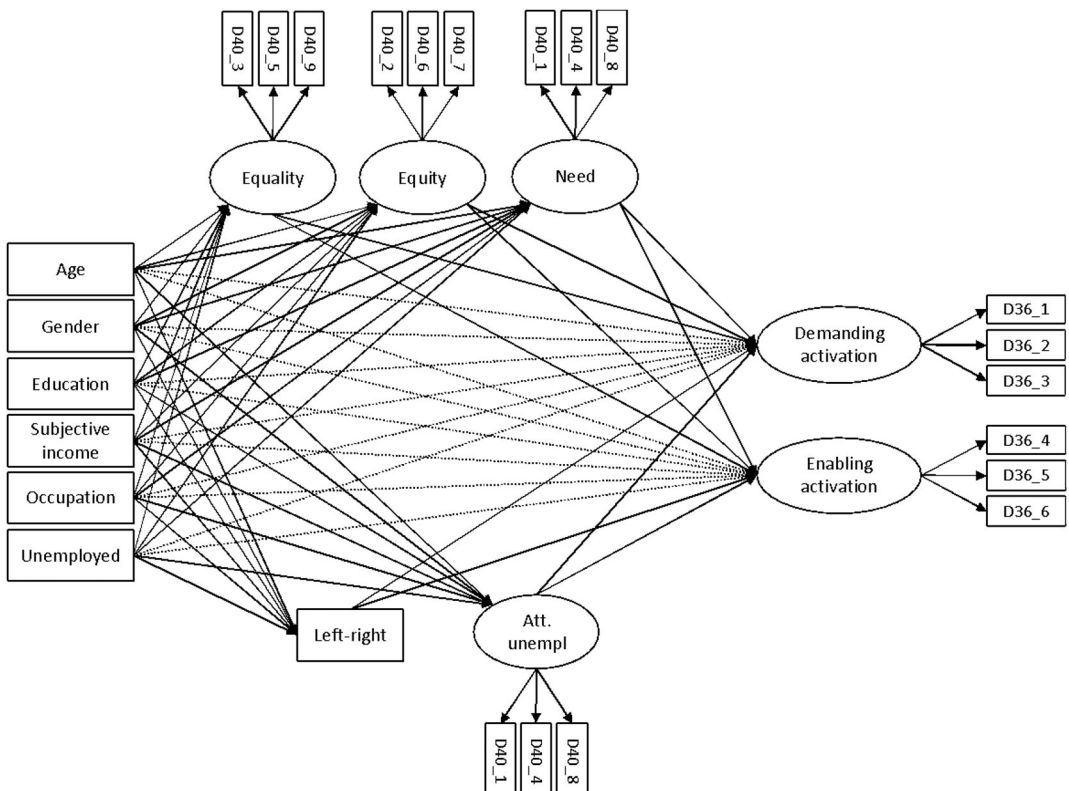


FIGURE 1 Graphical representation of the SEM explaining demanding and enabling activation.

Based on our theoretical expectations, the following hypotheses regarding the diverging explanations for demanding and enabling activation can be formulated:

For demanding activation:

- Being unemployed and having a lower socio-economic position (in terms of education, income and class) will lead to less support for demanding activation (H1a). These effects are expected to be direct, that is under control of differences in ideological preferences.
- Individuals on the right of the political spectrum will be more supportive of demanding activation (H2a) compared to those on the left of the political spectrum.
- Social justice preferences for equity (H3a) are conducive to support for demanding activation. As for the effect of the principle of need, we have conflicting expectations and no clear hypotheses.
- Negative attitudes towards the unemployed will positively relate to support for demanding activation (H4a).

For enabling activation:

- Being unemployed and having a lower socio-economic position (in terms of education, income and class) will lead to more support for enabling activation (H1b). These effects are expected to be direct, that is under control of differences in ideological preferences.
- Individuals on the right of the political spectrum will be less supportive of enabling activation (H2b) compared to those on the left of the political spectrum.
- Social justice preferences for equality (H3b) will strengthen support for enabling activation. As for the effect of the principle of need, we have conflicting expectations and no clear hypotheses.
- Negative attitudes towards the unemployed will negatively relate to support for enabling activation (H4b).

3 | DATA & METHODS

3.1 | Dataset

Our hypotheses were tested using data from the 2020 Belgian National Election Study (Meuleman et al., 2021), which is based on a two-stage random probability sample of Belgian adults eligible to vote. The survey took place between December 2019 and October 2020, with a temporary interruption due to the COVID-19 pandemic. A total of 1659 respondents participated in the survey, of which 75.8% were interviewed using the originally planned CAPI (computer-assisted personal interview) mode. Due to the pandemic, respondents who were reluctant to allow interviewers into their homes were given the option to participate through a self-completion online survey (19.5%) or a video interview (4.4%). The overall response rate obtained was 32.8%. Following the initial survey, respondents were invited to participate in an additional, shorter drop-off questionnaire, of which 1129 of the initial respondents (68.1%) took part. Our analysis is limited to respondents who completed the drop-off, as several key measures (activation attitudes, social justice beliefs, and attitudes towards the unemployed; see further) were included in this section. To account for potential non-response bias in both stages of the survey, all results were either post-stratified for age, gender, and education or controlled for these variables.

3.2 | Indicators

Dependent variable: Support for demanding and enabling activation – We operationalise support for demanding activation using three Likert-type items (five-point disagree-agree scales) referring to obligations for the unemployed to

accept jobs (D36_1), controlling job search activities (D36_2), and sanction for unemployed who fail to comply (D36_3). These items are selected from a longer scale analysed by Rossetti et al. (2022) and Van Hootegeem et al. (2021).

To measure support for enabling activation, three new items were purposefully developed. These statements mention the need to invest in the upskilling (D36_4) and job counselling (D36_5) of the unemployed, as well as providing temporary financial incentives to re-enter the labour market (D36_6). Table 1 includes the exact wording of the items. The validity of this two-dimensional instrument is discussed in the results section.

Social-structural predictors – Various indicators are used to measure individuals social-structural position. Education is categorised as lower secondary education or less, higher secondary education, and tertiary education. Income is the net equivalised household income divided into four quartiles. Due to a substantial amount of item non-response on the income variable, a separate missing category is included. Occupational class is divided into five categories based on the Erikson-Goldthorpe-Portocarero class scheme: service class, blue collar workers, white collar workers, self-employed, and persons who have never been active in the labour market (including students). The model furthermore includes an indicator of current unemployment. Gender and age are included as control variables. Descriptive statistics for these variables can be found in Appendix A1 (see Data S1).

Ideological dimensions – First, political left–right self-placement is measured on a scale from 0 (very left) to 10 (very right). Second, preferences for three *social justice principles* (equality, equity and need) are measured using a slightly modified version of the Basic Social Justice Orientations scale (Hülle et al., 2017; Van Hootegeem et al., 2021). Each justice principle is measured by three items inviting respondents to rate the fairness of a particular situation – from 1 (very unjust) to 5 (very just). Equality is measured by items referring to the desirability of small differences in income, living standards and wealth. Need is operationalised through items mentioning taking care only of those who are in need, who are poor or who have low incomes. The equity questions refer to rewards for hard-work, performance, and achievement. Third, *attitudes towards the unemployed* are captured through three statements alluding to negative stereotypes about unemployed individuals, namely that they do not try to get a job (D17_1), live a comfortable life at the expense of society (D17_2), and collect benefits that they are not entitled to (D17_3). The exact wording of the ideology-items, as well as a Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) confirming the validity of the scales is included in Appendix A2 (see Data S1).

TABLE 1 Results of a confirmatory factor analysis for demanding versus enabling activation support.

		Support demanding activation	Support enabling activation
D36_1	The long-term unemployed should be obliged to accept any job, even if they would earn less than before	0.700***	
D36_2	The government should control more strictly if the unemployed apply for enough jobs	0.826***	
D36_3	Welfare beneficiaries who fail to meet their obligations, should be punished more strongly	0.742***	
D36_4	The government should allocate more money to re-educate the unemployed		0.719***
D36_5	The government should invest more in providing personalised guidance to the unemployed to increase their chance of getting a job		0.938***
D36_6	The government should offer temporary financial incentives to the unemployed people who accept a low-paid job.		0.398***
Correlation Demanding – Enabling		–0.063	

Note: Fit indices: Chi-square = 48.53; Df = 8; RMSEA = 0.067; CFI = 0.979; TLI = 0.961; SRMR = 0.044. ****p* < 0.001; ***p* < 0.01; **p* < 0.05.

Source: Belgian National Elections Study 2020.

3.3 | Statistical modelling

For several reasons, this contribution makes use of Structural Equation Modelling (SEM). First, SEM is a latent variable technique that enables to evaluate the measurement quality of constructs and take random measurement error into account. Second, SEM facilitates estimating mediation models with direct and indirect effects. This feature is particularly valuable in the explanatory models, where the impact of social-structural variables on activation attitudes is mediated by ideological dimensions, as depicted in Figure 1.

All statistical models are estimated using *Mplus* 8.4, using the default Full Information Maximum Likelihood (FIML) estimator. This estimator efficiently deals with item non-response, as it retains the full information available in the dataset through pairwise deletion in the covariance structure. The reported parameters are standardised, with the exception of the effects of the dummy variables, which are semi-standardised. As a result, the effects of dummy variables refer to the difference with the reference category in terms of standard deviations on the dependent variable. To improve the accuracy of statistical inference for the indirect effects, bootstrapped standard errors (with 5000 replications) are reported (Asparouhov & Muthén, 2010).

4 | RESULTS

4.1 | Measuring demanding versus enabling activation: Descriptive results and measurement validation

Figure 2 visualises the response patterns for the items measuring support for demanding (D36_1-D36_3) and enabling (D36_4-D36_6) activation. Belgian citizens show a relatively high level of support for demanding activation policies. Almost 6 out of 10 Belgians agree with the statement that long-term unemployed persons should be required to accept job offers, even if it entails a decrease in salary compared to their previous employment (D36_1). Similarly, 72% of the population supports the idea of strict government controls of search activities (D36_2), while 66% endorse sanctions for unemployed individuals who fail to comply with the obligations (D36_3). Opposition against these demanding activation policies remains relatively low (21%, 10% and 9%, respectively).

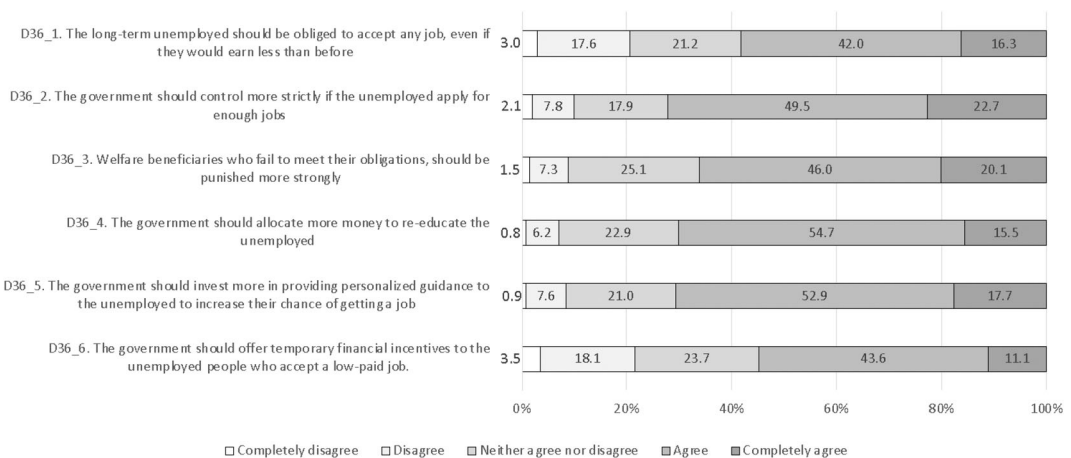


FIGURE 2 Frequency distribution of the items measuring demanding and enabling activation ($N = 1129$). The percentages are weighted for gender, age, and education. Source: Belgian National Elections Study 2020.

Interestingly, support for enabling activation measures is at least as strong as support for demanding activation. More than 70% of respondents supports higher investments in re-education opportunities (D36_4) or personal guidance (D36_5) for unemployed individuals. The idea of providing temporary financial incentives for unemployed entering low-paid segments of the labour market (alluding to in-work-benefits or fiscal incentivisation) is the least popular of all measurements, but it is still endorsed by 55% of Belgians.

Our analysis focuses on the underlying attitudinal dimensions rather than individual items. Table 1 summarises the findings of a CFA assessing the validity and reliability of the measurement of these latent variables. The CFA confirms that a two-dimensional structure, differentiating between demanding from enabling activation support, adequately accounts for the pattern of covariances between the items. The fit indices (such as RMSEA, CFI, TLI and SRMR) indicate that this two-dimensional model has a good fit to the data and is hence appropriate to describe the data.

For the three items measuring demanding activation support, the factor loadings are very high (>0.70), which implies that the items are strong indicators of the underlying construct. Regarding the factor measuring support for enabling activation, two out of three items perform excellently, with factor loadings of 0.72 (D36_4) and 0.94 (D36_5), respectively. The near-perfect factor loading for D36_5 suggests that Belgians' attitudinal concept of enabling activation is almost identical to the idea of public investment for job counselling. Item D36_6, however, has a weaker factor loading (0.40).³ Although the logic of fiscal incentivisation fits theoretically well with enabling activation, this link is not clearly reflected in the attitudes of the Belgian citizens. Possible explanations for this discrepancy could be the complexity of the fiscal system or the vagueness of the statement, which leaves open the specific modalities of the financial bonus and its funding source (government or employer).

The CFA model detects a correlation between demanding and enabling activation support that is negative but small and statistically insignificant (-0.063 ; $p = 0.071$). Respondents' stance on demanding activation is unrelated to their view on enabling activation, and vice versa. Although both types of activation policies receive rather similar levels of support, they represent two clearly distinct attitude objects. This finding underscores the importance of disentangling the two attitudinal dimensions, and is in line with the findings of Garritzmman et al. (2018), who detect that public support for workfare and social investment are 2 distinct factors.

4.2 | Explaining support for demanding and enabling activation

The clearly distinct nature of the two faces of activation support is further illuminated through the explanation models. Table 2 reports the effects of various social-structural variables and ideological predictors. These effects in Table 2 stem from a SEM, wherein the effects of the social-structural variables are mediated by ideological dispositions (see Figure 1). This SEM mediation approach allows us to disentangle total, direct and indirect effects. In other words, the table shows what the effect of social-structural variables is with (direct effects) and without (total effects) controlling for ideological dispositions.

With respect to their ideological drivers, support for demanding and enabling activation are almost mirror images of each other. Support for demanding ALMPs is strongly related to a preference for the justice principle of equity ($\beta = 0.467$; $p < 0.001$), which confirms H3a. Furthermore, a stronger emphasis on need as a justice principle reduces support for demanding activation ($\beta = -0.145$; $p < 0.05$). This aligns with the findings of Van Hootegem, Abts, and Meuleman (2023), who utilised a similar measurement of need. It supports the interpretation that need, at least in this operationalization, refers more to concern for the well-being of the needy rather than supporting a residual welfare state. Conversely, support for enabling activation is linked to the equality principle (see H3b). Individuals endorsing equality as a principle tend to be more supportive of enabling activation (although this relationship is not very strong; $\beta = 0.150$; $p < 0.05$).

The attitude towards the unemployed shows a very divergent effect on the two dimensions of activation support as well. Stereotypical negative beliefs about unemployed are strongly and positively related to demanding

TABLE 2 Explanation models for support for demanding and enabling activation – direct, indirect and total effects (N = 1105).

	Support for demanding activation						Support for enabling activation					
	Direct effects			Indirect effects			Total effects			Direct effects		
	ParEst	SE	Sign	ParEst	SE	Sign	ParEst	SE	Sign	ParEst	SE	Sign
Age	0.021	(0.036)		0.037	(0.035)		0.058	(0.036)		0.079	(0.036)	*
Gender										0.016	(0.017)	
Woman (ref.)												
Man	0.080	(0.072)		−0.039	(0.064)		0.042	(0.071)		0.021	(0.073)	
Education												
Lower (secondary)	−0.124	(0.101)		0.297	(0.105)	*	0.173	(0.107)		0.042	(0.109)	
Higher secondary	−0.069	(0.078)		0.279	(0.079)	***	0.209	(0.080)	*	−0.110	(0.084)	
Tertiary (ref.)												
Occupation												
Blue collar (ref.)												
Service class	−0.058	(0.093)		−0.043	(0.091)		−0.101	(0.099)		−0.151	(0.099)	
White collar	0.045	(0.101)		−0.133	(0.093)		−0.089	(0.108)		−0.113	(0.110)	
Self-employed	−0.089	(0.136)		0.279	(0.113)	*	0.190	(0.129)		−0.222	(0.149)	
Inactive	0.026	(0.133)		−0.154	(0.128)		−0.129	(0.137)		−0.064	(0.123)	
Unemployment status												
Not unemployed (ref.)												
Unemployed	−0.334	(0.212)		−0.501	(0.234)	*	−0.835	(0.253)	***	0.185	(0.252)	
Subjective income												
Just or not enough	0.006	(0.112)		−0.425	(0.118)	***	−0.420	(0.111)	***	0.036	(0.136)	
Sufficient	0.106	(0.076)		−0.235	(0.090)	*	−0.129	(0.086)		−0.018	(0.100)	
More than enough (ref.)												
Equality	−0.069	(0.060)							*	0.150	(0.059)	*
Equity	0.467	(0.091)	***							0.001	(0.098)	

TABLE 2 (Continued)

	Support for demanding activation						Support for enabling activation					
	Direct effects			Indirect effects			Direct effects			Indirect effects		
	ParEst	SE	Sign	ParEst	SE	Sign	ParEst	SE	Sign	ParEst	SE	Sign
Need	−0.145	(0.069)	*				0.098	(0.076)				
Attitude unempl.	0.454	(0.056)	***				−0.179	(0.055)	***			
Left-right placement	0.035	(0.039)					−0.042	(0.039)				
R ²	0.632						0.105					

Note: Fit indices: Chi-square = 607.71; Df = 264; RMSEA = 0.034; CFI = 0.946; TLI = 0.922; SRMR = 0.039. Entries are parameter estimates (ParEst), Standard Errors (SE) and indication of statistical significance (Sig): *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$. Parameter estimates are standardised (for continuous predictors) or semi-standardised (for categorical predictors). Source: Belgian National Elections Study 2020.

activation support ($\beta = 0.454$; $p < 0.001$), but negatively linked to enabling activation support ($\beta = -0.179$; $p < 0.001$), confirming H4a and H4b, respectively. Interestingly, in contrast to prior studies (Buss, 2018; Fossati, 2018; Laenen & Meuleman, 2019), political left-right placement is not related to either dimension of activation support, thereby rejecting H2a and H2b. At first sight, this result also seems to be odds with the results of Garritzmman et al. (2018), who show that economic left-right positions and the GAL-TAN dimension explain public support for workfare as well as social investment policies. However, additional analyses (results not shown here) indicate that left-right placement becomes significant when social justice principles and attitudes towards the unemployed are left out from the model. The effects are in line with hypotheses 2a and 2b: left-leaning individuals are more supportive of enabling activation, but less enthusiastic about demanding activation (which is similar to Garritzmman et al., 2018). That the left-right effect disappears after including social justice preferences and attitudes towards the unemployed illustrates that these specific ideological dispositions are more suitable to understand activation support than the generic left-right dimension.

Summarising, the pattern of divergent effects highlights the markedly different ideological underpinnings of the attitudes towards the two faces of activation. The support base for demanding policies, which involves stringent monitoring and sanctioning of the unemployed, predominantly consists of individuals who have negative attitudes towards the unemployed and who stress the logic of equity, while putting less emphasis on need as a basis for redistribution. Conversely, positive attitudes towards the unemployed and a stronger preference for equality strengthen support for enabling policies aimed at improving the human capital of the unemployed.

Compared to the ideological predictors, the effects of the social-structural predictors are less pronounced and clear-cut. Analysing the total effects (that is, the effect of the social-structural variables without controlling for ideological dispositions), only a limited number of the variables significantly relate to activation support.⁴ Support for demanding activation is weaker among the unemployed and those with a low subjective income. Superficially, one might interpret these patterns as driven by self-interested concerns. However, our findings contradict this interpretation. Notably, none of the direct effects on support for demanding activation are statistically significant. Instead, the observed effects are primarily indirect, mediated by ideological factors. Exploring the relationship between social-structural characteristics and ideological dispositions (see Appendix A3 – Data S1) reveals that the unemployed tend to hold less negative stereotypical beliefs about unemployed individuals, while those with low (subjective) incomes exhibit a preference for equality and a disfavour for equity. These differences in ideological composition can explain the effects of unemployment status and subjective income, implying that empirical evidence does not support the self-interest hypothesis (H1a). Furthermore, the models also indicate that not completing tertiary education and being self-employed have a positive indirect effect on support for activation. These indirect effects can be traced back to the prevalence of negative stereotypes about unemployed among the lower-educated; while the self-employed tend to emphasise the justice principle of equity and hold more negative attitudes towards unemployed persons.

In the case of enabling activation, effects of self-interest variables are completely absent (refuting H2b). We only find a small positive effect of the control variable age ($\beta = 0.095$; $p < 0.01$), which operates primarily directly ($\beta = 0.079$; $p < 0.05$). However, an explanation for why enabling activation is more popular among elderly respondents is not immediately clear.

Finally, it is noteworthy that the explanatory power for demanding activation support ($R^2 = 63.2\%$) exceeds that of enabling activation support ($R^2 = 10.5\%$) by far. This disparity is in the first place due to the difference in size of the ideological effects, coupled with a complete absence of social-structural effects for enabling activation. This demonstrates that demanding activation is much more transparent as a crystallised ideological project for the public at large, clearly targeting an undeserving group with stringent control and sanctions. On the other hand, enabling activation draws upon ideas from both the political left and right, rendering its ideological impetus less evident.

5 | CONCLUSION

This study made a systematic comparison between public support for demanding and enabling activation policies. Specifically, we have explored whether explanatory mechanisms previously identified for demanding activation support can be extended to encompass support for enabling activation policies as well. In addition to often-used predictors related to self-interest and generic left-right ideology, this study examines how ideological dispositions such as distributive justice principles and attitudes towards the unemployed, shape activation attitudes. Our findings offer new insights into the distinct nature and explanatory mechanisms of public support for the two faces of activation. This type of information is not only interesting from a scientific perspective but is also relevant for policy makers. Public opinion cannot answer the question what approach towards activation is preferable. Yet, it does show where potential conflict lines in society are located and what type of policies are perceived as legitimate by which social groups.

First, our findings demonstrate that individuals differentiate clearly between the two policy paradigms (even if both forms receive widespread support in Belgian population). That both policies represent distinct attitude objects underscores the necessity to disentangle the roots of both types of support. Second, our study highlights that support for both types of activation are strongly rooted in ideological dispositions, albeit with markedly distinct underpinnings in terms of justice preferences and stereotypes about the unemployed.

Normative beliefs of distributive justice play a crucial role in shaping activation preferences. Support for enabling activation is associated with the social justice principle of equality, signifying that individuals who value equality – probably, equality of opportunity – are more inclined towards enabling policies. From this perspective, activation considers public investments in human capital as universal and unconditional rights aimed at empowering citizens (Watts & Fitzpatrick, 2018). Conversely, support for demanding activation policies is strongly linked to a preference for equity, as individuals endorsing this principle are more likely to support rigorous monitoring and sanctioning of the unemployed for non-compliance with obligations, thereby rebalancing the social contract between citizens and state. The principle of need was, conversely, associated with less support for demanding ALMPs. Theoretically, it is equally plausible that need would promote support for work obligations as it aligns with a residual form of welfare distribution that promotes self-reliance. Our finding thus points to an alternative interpretation of need as a preoccupation with the well-being of those in need (Kittel, 2020). This need effect found here could be driven by our operationalization of need, which referred explicitly to the importance of guaranteeing basic needs.

Negative stereotypes about the unemployed were found to be positively correlated with support for demanding activation policies, but negatively associated with enabling activation support. Specifically, individuals who perceive the unemployed as lazy and unwilling to find a job are more likely to support strict sanctions and benefit cuts as effective means to force those with a weak work ethic to re-enter employment (Dwyer, 2000). Conversely, those who attribute unemployment to a lack of individual responsibility are less inclined to endorse supportive public interventions that aim to improve employability through ‘social investment’.

Surprisingly, we did not find any significant relationship between individuals' political left-right placement and either dimension of activation support. This lack of association could be attributed to the strong predictive influence of other ideological dispositions, thereby overshadowing the impact of traditional political ideology. Our findings emphasise the necessity to include ideology in empirical studies at a more specific level of abstraction than relying on generic left-right measurements (cf. Bauer et al., 2017).

The effects of socio-structural variables are considerably weaker compared to the ideological predictors, but still provide valuable insights. None of the socio-structural characteristics has a significant direct effect on support for both types of activation policies. The limited effects of social-structural variables, particularly on support for demanding activation, are mediated via ideological considerations. That certain social strata show greater resistance against demanding activation is not driven by material self-interest or cost-benefit calculations but rooted in normative beliefs. For the unemployed for instance, their aversion of negative stereotyping about the unemployed plays a crucial role in shaping their opposition against demanding activation. Principles of justice are more significant in shaping the stance of the low-income group towards demanding activation, as they tend to favour equality and oppose equity. These findings underscore the need to carefully consider the underlying ideological logics behind the effects of socio-structural

variables. Our findings indicate that these socio-economic characteristics should not be treated as univocal indicators of self-interest, but rather be seen as a part of a habitus that connects social structure with cultural dispositions.

Overall, our study reveals that support for demanding activation policies is firmly rooted in a specific justice conception that prioritises contributions to the common good and a quid-pro-quo welfare model, alongside discourses that stereotype the unemployed as non-reliant. The approach to demanding activation policies aligns with producerism (Abts et al., 2021), a doctrine that individualises the causes and solutions of unemployment and divides society into 'productive' and 'unproductive' groups. This focus on moral discipline implies a punitive role for the government in establishing and preserving this moral order, including the implementation of sanctions for those perceived as lacking self-responsibility and non-compliance with societal norms. In contrast, public support for enabling activation displays a blurrier ideological profile and normative foundation, as it incorporates ideas originating from both the political left and right. Due to its ideological ambiguity, support for enabling activation can be interpreted through various heuristics, making its ideological foundations less evident to the public, but also able to attract a broader part of the public. This may explain the less consolidated nature of attitudes towards enabling activation, as they do not strongly align with social structural and ideological divisions. An alternative explanation could be linked to the high level of politicisation of the demanding aspects of unemployment benefits and the attention they received in the media. The fact that several governments in Belgium have recently proposed measures towards increasing conditionality and strengthening sanctions for the unemployed might have made the demanding face of activation more visible, thereby blurring societal divisions on the issue of enabling activation.

This brings us to the questions of the generalizability of these findings stemming from a Belgian context. While it is difficult to predict whether our findings could be applied to other policy contexts, we expect similar patterns at least in other European countries where unemployment benefit system are in the centre of societal debates and politicians use the rhetoric of the 'lazy unemployed' as a strategy to bring forward strict measure against this group. It remains to be seen whether in countries with a longer tradition of active labour market policies, such as Scandinavian countries, the electorate could be divided more strongly on the two sides of activation.

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DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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ENDNOTES

- ¹ Activation is often used to indicate only active labour market policies. This article focuses on these policies, which according to Bonoli (2010) constitute the cornerstone of the active welfare state. For an up-to-date review of the concept and research themes which fall under the activation concept, see Clasen and Mascaro (2022).
- ² Although the justice principle of equity strongly overlaps with the criterion of reciprocity used to describe the deservingness of specific groups of claimants in welfare state research (van Oorschot et al., 2017), we follow the distributive justice literature that describes equity as one of three fundamental justice principles organizing welfare state distributions.
- ³ Despite the weaker factor loading, we decide to keep item D36_6 in to cover the variety of approaches to enabling activation as good as possible. When the analysis is repeated without item D36_6, however, the result remain unchanged: also with a reduced 2-item scale, we find 2 clearly distinct dimensions, and the findings regarding the predictors remain intact as well.

⁴ Looking at proportions of explained variance confirms the finding that social-structural variables have little explanatory power. A model with socio-demographic variables only explains 6.6 and 2.6% of the variation in support for demanding and enabling activation respectively. Adding the ideological predictors increases these R-squared values to 63.2 and 10.5%, respectively. This is very steep increase, especially in the case of demanding activation.

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section at the end of this article.

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